A second worry is the threat to the island's rare and endemic biodiversity. Great Nicobar's beaches, including Galathea Bay, host roughly 650 nesting sites of the endangered leatherback turtle, and increased port activity could imperil hatchling survival. Though the MoEFF says it has announced a 13.75 sq. km reserve for leatherback turtles at Little Nicobar, a 1.29 sq. km sanctuary for megapodes at Menchal island and 2.73 sq. km coral sanctuary at Meroe island to protect the island's wildlife, environmentalists remain unconvinced about the adequacy of the proposed mitigation measures.

Beyond habitat loss, conservationists also warn of the cascading effects from a massive influx of people into the fragile ecosystem. The island's population could swell from about 8,500 today to 650,000 by 2050, even as the entire Andaman and Nicobar archipelago has fewer than 450,000 residents currently. Concerns range from increased waste and pollution to freshwater scarcity, invasive species and fragmentation of remaining forests.

The stakes extend beyond Great Nicobar itself. The island's coral reefs—already stressed by warming seas—play a crucial role in the larger marine biodiversity in the Andaman Sea and Bay of Bengal. Their degradation could have far-reaching consequences for fisheries and ocean health across the region. The NGT, in its recent order, upheld the Zoological Survey of India's (ZSI) contention that while there are no corals in the project area, there are 309 species of corals in the peninsular area of Galathea Bay. Of the 20,668 coral colonies identified, the ZSI has proposed a relocation of 16,150 such colonies found up to 15 metres depth and for 4,518 from between 15 and 30 metres depth. The tribunal accepted the proposal, but has said it should be studied further before any relocation takes place. The ZSI cited prior experience—such as coral relocation in the Gulf of Kachchh—where survival rates were reported at around 90 per cent.

THE TRIBAL DISPLACEMENT

The third major area of disquiet is the deleterious impact the project is likely to have on Great Nicobar's two indigenous tribes—the Shompens and the Nicobarese—and their way of life. As much as 84.1 sq. km, or 11 per cent, of the tribal reserve falls within the project area. The government claims it secured the consent of these tribes for the project. But on January 22, 2026, the tribal council chiefs of Great Nicobar held a press conference, alleging that they had been asked to sign documents surrendering their claims over ancestral land they had occupied before the 2004 tsunami. Barnabas Manju, head of the tribal council, told the media that once he realised the extent of the land being sought, he wrote to the administration withdrawing his consent.



"There is clear evidence the project will have disastrous ecological impact. The conditions for its clearance the NGT draws reference to will do little to deal with these long-term consequences"

JAIRAM RAMESH
Former Union environment minister

Bhupender Yadav has categorically stated that the Shompen and Nicobarese settlements in Rajiv Nagar and New Chingen will not be displaced. In fact, his ministry claims a net gain of 3.91 sq. km for the tribal reserve through areas being renotified elsewhere. Yet Manish Chandi, a social ecologist who has studied the indigenous islanders for more than two decades, warns, "There is worldwide experience to suggest that whenever a community engaged in a hunter-gatherer life is exposed to a modern infrastructure project, the impact has been extremely adverse. They have chosen this life, and an alternate one cannot be imposed on them."

Adding to the unease are the geological vulnerabilities of Great Nicobar. The island, according to Janki Andharia, professor at the Centre for Disasters and Development, Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS), Mumbai, falls in Zone V, the highest seismic hazard region. Data from the United States Geological Survey shows that, between 2010 and 2020, 442 earthquakes with magnitudes ranging from 4.0 to 6.6 occurred within a 150 km radius of the island, indicating an average of 44 earthquakes every year. Andharia points to the 2004 tsunami as a testimony to the extent of destruction seismic activity can inflict on a region, and a large population living on the island would arguably be at massive risk. The MoEFCC claims that the possibility of another 2004-like "mega earthquake is low" since seismologists say such incidents recur only in 420-750-year cycles.

Senior MoEFCC officials say they have gone beyond their usual remit and set up three high-powered committees to oversee pollution issues, biodiversity threats and tribal welfare to ensure the implementation of the environment management plan. Meanwhile, the legal battle has shifted to the Calcutta High Court, which is hearing petitions from ecologists challenging the project. In many ways, the Great Nicobar Island Project encapsulates a larger national dilemma: how to balance economic ambition and strategic imperatives with environmental conservation and the rights of indigenous peoples—without irreparably damaging one of India's last great wildernesses. ■

-with Pradip R. Sagar and M.G. Arun